

Resource Guide for AI Governance in HR

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Initiatives: Technologies and Markets; Transform HR through AI

CHROs who fail to address AI governance in HR risk compliance failures, ethical dilemmas, diminished employee trust, and inconsistent business outcomes. Use this resource guide to identify critical activities for developing AI governance and risk management capabilities for the HR function.

Analysis

Although this resource guide can be used as stand-alone research to address AI governance for the HR function, we recommend that CHROs complete an AI maturity assessment for HR to address any gaps along the way (see [Tool: AI Maturity Assessment for HR](#) and [Tool: AI Roadmap for HR](#)).

AI governance is a critical capability for responsible and effective AI adoption in HR. Yet, 57% of HR leaders report that their organization either has ad hoc, separate AI initiatives throughout the organization or lacks well-defined central AI governance policies and strategy. ¹

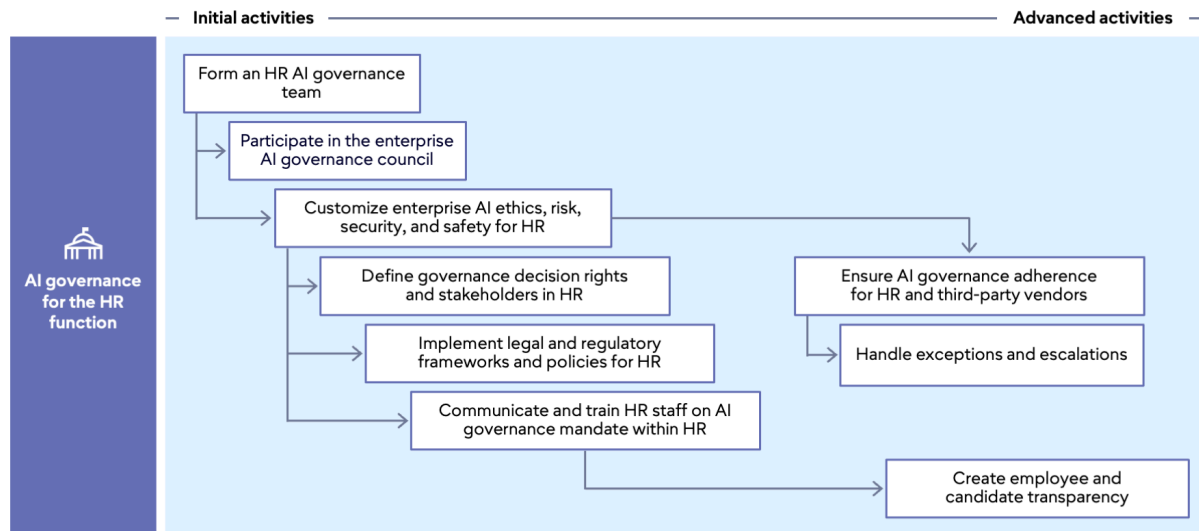
Position: Treating AI governance as a centralized compliance exercise guarantees HR will expose the enterprise to unchecked risks.

Despite AI's many potential benefits, it also introduces specific limitations and risks, such as algorithmic bias in talent decisions and privacy concerns regarding sensitive employee data, that must be identified and mitigated. Additionally, HR functions must build trust among employees, candidates, and stakeholders while ensuring compliance with regional, national, and industry-specific AI-related regulations.

Over time, these efforts should evolve into a more structured and formal governance approach, including clearly defined decision rights, escalation pathways, and third-party vendor oversight processes. Ultimately, HR functions should establish a framework that balances HR innovation and agility with appropriate control, accountability, and compliance (see Figure 1).

Figure 1: AI Governance for the HR Function Roadmap Activities

AI Governance for the HR Function Roadmap Activities



Source: Gartner
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Research Highlights

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CHROs can use the journey outlined in Table 1 to build a roadmap of activities that will lead to a systematic approach to AI governance for their HR function.

Table 1: Roadmap for Developing AI Governance for the HR Function

Initiate AI Governance for HR	Formalize AI Governance for HR	Optimize AI Governance for HR
Form an HR AI Governance Team	Customize Enterprise AI Ethics and Risks, Security, and Safety for HR	Ensure AI Governance Adherence for HR and Third-Party Vendors
Participate in the Enterprise AI Governance Council	Define Governance Decision Rights and Stakeholders in HR	Handle Exceptions and Escalations
	Implement Legal and Regulatory Frameworks and Policies for HR	Create Employee and Candidate Transparency
Communicate and Train HR Staff on AI Governance Mandate Within HR		

Source: Gartner (May 2026)

Initiate AI Governance for HR

Most large organizations already have a central enterprise AI governance function. However, enterprise AI governance alone is often insufficient to address the unique workforce, compliance, and operational risks associated with AI use in HR. HR should establish a dedicated HR AI governance team while also participating in the enterprise AI governance council to ensure HR-specific risks and workforce impacts are represented in enterprisewide AI decisions. This enables organizations to align enterprise AI policies and standards with the realities of HR processes such as hiring, performance management, compensation, and retention.

Form an HR AI Governance Team

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Steps:

- Clarify the purpose, the mandate and the scope of the HR AI governance team.

- Select members from key functional HR domains (e.g., HR technology, HR operations, talent COE, HRBP, etc.).
- Define clear roles and responsibilities and establish ownership.
- Set team meeting structure, cadence, escalation paths and decision-making workflows.
- Align with enterprise AI governance structures to ensure consistency.

Recommended Research:

- [Toolkit: Setting Up a Committee Charter for AI Governance](#)
- [Key First Steps to Govern AI in HR Before Scaling It](#)

Participate in the Enterprise AI Governance Council

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Steps:

- Nominate either yourself (as the CHRO) or your AI product leader and assign decision authority and strong business understanding.
- Define governance input areas and clarify where HR contributes (e.g., workforce impact, employee data usage, ethical considerations, etc.).
- Establish structured reporting mechanisms from HR toward the enterprise AI governance council and HR AI use cases, risks or policy implications.
- Continuously communicate HR-specific risks, insights and emerging HR-related AI challenges.
- Ensure enterprise decisions are translated and reported back to the HR AI governance team to ensure enterprise decisions are adapted into frameworks, policies and controls for HR.

Recommended Research:

- [The Boardroom Guide to AI Governance and Risk Oversight](#)
- [How to Build a Lightweight Organizational Structure for AI Governance](#)

Formalize AI Governance for HR

With the number of AI initiatives growing, AI governance needs to be implemented as a more structured and formalized approach. The aim here is to enable the safe scaling of AI in HR while maintaining control over security, safety, and ethical risks. This requires adapting and adhering to policies and different legal and regulatory frameworks, explicit stakeholder decision rights, and clear communication and training.

Customize Enterprise AI Ethics and Risks, Security, and Safety for HR

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Steps:

- Identify HR-specific risk areas (e.g., bias in talent decisions, explainability of AI-driven recommendations, employee data privacy concerns, access to sensitive employee data, etc.).
- Translate enterprise AI principles, risk frameworks, and security requirements into HR-specific guidance for each use case.
- Define HR-specific:
 - AI policies and controls to evaluate acceptable versus unacceptable AI use cases in HR processes and integrate reviews into approval workflows
 - AI risk management frameworks, policies and controls to evaluate low-risk versus high-risk AI use cases in HR and define mitigation measures (e.g., human-in-the-loop bias testing or data minimization)
 - AI security frameworks, policies and controls to govern access to sensitive employee data; enable secure deployment of AI tools in HR environments; and align with IT on infrastructure, vendor security, and system integration requirements
- Enable awareness and training on responsible AI in HR while implementing risk monitoring and security monitoring to detect misuse risks, unauthorized access, data leakages, and/or unintended model behavior.

Recommended Research:

- [Responsible AI at Work: Six Principles for CHROs to Mitigate Risk at Scale](#)
- [Tool: Generative AI Policy Kit](#)

- [Case Study: An AI Governance Framework for Managing Use Case Ethics](#)
- [Tool: Identify and Mitigate Top GenAI Usage Risks](#)

Define Governance Decision Rights and Stakeholders in HR

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Steps:

- Identify key HR AI decisions and decision types (e.g., use-case approval, vendor selection, risk classification).
- Define decision rights and authority levels for the HR AI governance team versus the enterprise AI governance council.
- Create governance workflows and escalation paths to define how decisions are made, reviewed, and escalated in high-risk cases.
- Implement clear documentation standards to ensure accountability and auditability.

Recommended Research:

- [Artificial Intelligence Requires an Extended Governance Framework](#)
- [How to Design an Effective AI Governance Operating Model](#)
- [Create an AI Literacy Roadmap to Drive Responsible and Productive AI](#)

Implement Legal and Regulatory Frameworks and Policies for HR

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Steps:

- Collaborate with the enterprise AI governance council to identify relevant legal and regulatory AI regulations impacting HR AI use.
- Define how legal and regulatory AI regulations impact HR activities (e.g., automated decision making in hiring) and translate requirements into HR process guidelines.
- Integrate legal and regulatory reviews into HR use-case design, vendor selection and deployment.

- Define documentation and audit requirements to ensure traceability of AI decisions and compliance with legal and regulatory AI regulations.
- Align with legal, compliance and works councils to ensure stakeholder alignment, especially in regulated or employee-sensitive contexts.

Recommended Research:

- [Why Most HR AI Agent Pilots Will Fail — 7 Reality Checks for CHROs](#)
- [The White House Opens the Door for Federal AI Regulation in a National Policy Framework](#)

Communicate and Train HR Staff on AI Governance Mandate Within HR

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Steps:

- Develop and deliver presentations for HR leaders on the importance of AI governance, highlighting the HR-specific risks, the key regulations, and the strategic benefits for HR processes.
- Identify different employee personas (e.g., executives, managers, frontline staff) to determine their specific education needs and create a general awareness program regarding AI risks.
- Create detailed training for specific segments, including hands-on workshops, case studies, and Q&A sessions to clarify the governance mandate and gather feedback on AI-related concerns.
- Create and share simple materials (FAQs, infographics, guides) explaining the AI governance mandate, its HR relevance, and its impact on daily HR work.
- Hold regular briefings with HR managers to share updates and success stories while maintaining an ongoing process to keep stakeholders informed of AI advancements and regulatory changes.

Recommended Reading:

- [Board Briefing: AI Regulatory Updates](#)
- [Create an AI Literacy Roadmap to Drive Responsible and Productive AI](#)

Optimize AI Governance for HR

To optimize governance, CHROs oversee the strict maintenance of AI governance adherence across both HR and third-party vendors. This means championing the establishment of clear procedures for documenting exceptions in HR AI systems and serving as the ultimate point of escalation for unresolved or high-impact issues that deviate from enterprise requirements. Most importantly, the CHRO leads the effort to embed governance directly into HR's cultural norms, fostering widespread transparency and intrinsic understanding of its importance.

Ensure AI Governance Adherence for HR and Third-Party Vendors

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Steps:

- Establish a formal process to monitor, document and address deviations from governance policies, including clear escalation paths for issues that cannot be immediately resolved.
- Continuously monitor HR AI systems using automated tools and manual checks to identify bias, fairness issues, and data quality concerns, allowing for the prompt mitigation of risks as they arise.
- Perform scheduled, in-depth reviews of AI outputs and HR process outcomes to evaluate long-term adherence to governance standards and capture lessons learned for future improvement.
- Translate enterprise security principles into HR-specific controls, ensuring strict governance over sensitive employee data access and identifying safety areas unique to the HR function.
- Align with IT to ensure the secure deployment of AI tools – focusing on vendor security and system interfaces – while implementing ongoing monitoring to detect unauthorized access, data leakage, or unintended model behavior.

Recommended Reading:

- [Tool: Policy Template for Acceptable Use of Generative AI](#)
- [Ask Your HR Technology Vendors These Questions About AI Risks](#)

Handle Exceptions and Escalations

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Steps:

- Establish clear procedures for identifying and documenting exceptions in HR AI systems and processes that deviate from enterprise governance requirements.
- Assign responsibility for initial assessment and resolution of exceptions, ensuring prompt corrective actions and mitigations of compliance risks.
- Define escalation pathways for unresolved or high-impact exceptions, including criteria for when issues must be elevated to senior HR leadership or enterprise governance teams.
- Maintain records of exception handling and escalation outcomes, enabling ongoing review and continuous improvement of HR AI governance processes.

Recommended Reading:

- [Playbook: Redesigning HR Processes for AI](#)
- [AI Implementation Guide: Account Reconciliations](#)
- [Tool: Criteria for Leaders to Escalate Employee Change Concerns](#)

Create Employee and Candidate Transparency

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Steps:

- Communicate clear, accessible guidelines on how AI is used in HR, outlining what data is collected, how it's processed and what decisions AI supports.
- Inform employees and candidates on their rights related to AI in HR, including data access, correction, objection and appeal mechanisms for AI-driven decisions.
- Ensure transparent consent by notifying employees and candidates when their data will be used in AI systems, specifying the purpose and the scope before collection or processing.
- Maintain dedicated channels for employees and candidates to ask questions or raise concerns about AI in HR, ensuring timely, clear responses.

Recommended Reading:

- [Responsible AI at Work: Six Principles for CHROs to Mitigate Risk at Scale](#)
- [Top Practices for Governing Conversational AI Agents and Assistants](#)

Contributors

Eser Rizaoglu

Evidence

¹ **2026 Gartner C-Suite AI Survey.** This survey was conducted to understand how enterprises are approaching AI, including budget allocations, current state of implementation and impact, AI strategy, and use cases across key business functions. The functions covered in the survey include finance, HR, procurement, supply chain, marketing, sales, customer service, legal and compliance, IT, and product management. The research was conducted online from January through April 2026 among 1,303 respondents across various industries and regions, including North America (n = 671), EMEA (n = 425), Asia/Pacific (n = 141), LATAM (n = 65), and others (n = 1). Qualifying organizations reported enterprisewide annual revenue of at least \$50 million (or equivalent) in fiscal 2025. Participants were required to be either the most senior leader or one level below the most senior leader within their respective function and have familiarity with AI strategy, implementation, and budget for that function. Disclaimer: The results of this survey do not represent global findings or the market as a whole, but reflect the sentiments of the respondents and companies surveyed

Recommended by the Authors

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[Tool: AI Maturity Assessment for HR](#)

[Tool: AI Roadmap for HR](#)

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